

CENTRE STAGE Apeksha Niranjan performing Bharatanatyam

REZA JAVIDI

FESTIVAL ▼

DANCE O

Bharatanatyam artist Apeksha Niranjan Curie to the stage at the Mumbai Interna

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Bharatanatyam artist, choreographer and storyteller Apeksha Niranjan will present the inspirational life of Nobel Prize-winning scientist Marie Curie at the fifth Mumbai International Storytelling Festival (MIST), at NCPA, Mumbai, on August 15. Organised by the Mumbai Storytellers Society, the two-day festival explores this year's theme, *Earth Democracy*, rooted in the Sanskrit concept *Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam*, or 'the world is one family'. The programme brings together storytellers from India and abroad, celebrating oral traditions through performances

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MUSIC ▼

FINDING *Her Voice*

As she gears up to release a self-composed single, Madhubanti Bagchi says creating her own music is the only way to carve an identity beyond her blockbuster hits



It's been only two years since the success of the thumri 'Nazariya Ki Maari' from Sanjay Leela Bhansali's Netflix series *Heermandi* and the blockbuster item track 'Aaj Ki Raat' from *Stree 2*, but Madhubanti Bagchi has already positioned herself as the next big thing in Hindi female playback.

Snugly fitting in the space between Sunidhi Chauhan, Shilpa Rao and Shreya Ghoshal, the singer from mofussil Bengal is sought after in the recording booth by heavyweights such as Pritam, Vishal Bhardwaj and Sachin-Jigar. Last year's *Dhurandhar* featured her in the superhit 'Shararat'. "Playback singing pays the bills," Bagchi explains. "When it comes to my own music, and expressing who I am, I will do what I want."

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Bagchi, trained in the Agra gharana, but is equally fond of heavy metal and hip-hop and will soon release an original composition she has sung. Ignoring streaming services and record labels demanding short songs in fear of losing the listener's attention, Bagchi says her song is almost five minutes long. Bagchi wants to prove she isn't just 'Aaj Ki Raat', whose Hindustani classical laced with club beats